this context, then US President Bill Clinton's March 2000 visit to India is considered positively transformational.[72] Clinton did a five-hour stopover in Pakistan after spending five days in India, only to inform Musharraf that he had irrefutable evidence of the 'alarming level' of support that the ISI was providing to anti-India militant outfits, including the HuA.[73] Vajpayee paid a reciprocal visit to the US in September 2000 and sought deeper collaboration on counter-terrorism. The India-US Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism (JWG-CT) had been in place since February 2000. And foreign secretary Chokila Iyer undertook a series of trips to Washington for discussing modalities of bilateral cooperation on terrorism.[74] By 2001, as the MEA stated, there was increased recognition by the US of the problem of terrorism in South Asia and the nature and origin of cross-border terrorism in India.[75] Going one step further, N. N. Jha (then convener of foreign affairs for the BJP) argued that the JWG-CT was a sign that the US recognised India's emerging global status.[76] Gujral noted:

> At one stage the US needed the Taliban to pursue its economic and other operations in Central Asia. But information available now is that it is evolving other options in the region to protect and advance its interests. Whether this would be sufficient to make it swing to India's side is question that would have no definite answer at the moment.[77]

A similar JWG was formed with Russia in September 2000. These platforms allowed India to share its concerns regarding non-state militant actors in Pakistan and the Taliban's proactive military offensives in North Afghanistan with Moscow. Putin had put Russian forces on high alert in case offensive action was required. The Taliban's recognition of Chechnya-Ichkeria as independent Islamic states in January 2000 had irritated Moscow tremendously.[78] The destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas in March 2001 simply added fuel to this raging fire.

Two events in September 2001 fundamentally altered India and the US' strategy towards Afghanistan. On 9 September 2001, two Al Qaeda suicide bombers, pretending to be journalists, assassinated Ahmad Shah Massoud, India's closest ally in Afghanistan.[79] The bomb had been concealed in the video camera and the battery pack belt. Massoud was rushed to the Farkhor field hospital in Tajikistan that India was running for the UF, but died in the helicopter on the way. Another United Front official, Mohammad Aasim Suhail was also killed while former UF ambassador to India, Massoud Khalili and journalist